

NORRIS BEATS VERSTAPPEN IN MIAMI FOR FIRST F1 WIN

Lando Norris' victory in Miami is **McLaren's first** since the 2021 Italian Grand Prix.

Dipak Ragav

dipak.ragav@thehindu.co.in

Formula One is one of the most competitive elite sports in the world, with only 20 slots available each year. Being one of the top 20 drivers in this challenging motorsport category is a great achievement in itself.

It is quite difficult to get into F1, but it is even harder to sustain a spot on the grid. That's why, in the 75 years of the FIA Formula One World Championship, there have only been 113 Grand Prix winners.

On May 5, 2024, Lando Norris became the 114th member of an exclusive club when he won the Miami Grand Prix. Over the last four years, the McLaren driver has been one of the fastest drivers on the grid, extracting results in a tricky car in which his teammates have not been anywhere close to him in terms of performance.

Long time coming

Since making his debut in 2019, Norris' growth has been exponential, and he is already one of the highest-paid athletes in F1. After slowly finding his feet in the first two years, Norris has improved

in some areas, like his steel in wheel-to-wheel battles, especially on the opening laps. Combined with his sheer pace and superb ability to manage tyres, delivering consistent laps over a race distance, Norris has made a convincing case to be clubbed alongside Max Verstappen, Lewis Hamilton, and Charles Leclerc.

The only asterisk against him was that he had not won a race despite 15 podium finishes, though he has never had a race-winning McLaren under him. He came within four laps of winning the Russian GP in 2021, but a burst of rain and his team's indecision to leave him on a wet track meant he missed out on that opportunity. The 24-year-old has often been unfairly criticised for choking under pressure, but Miami was the first chance he had to go for the win, and he grabbed it with both hands in his 110th race. Now, with the weight off his shoulders, this could be the first of many for Norris.

Despair to delight

More than the win, it was how he went about in the race that showed why he is so highly rated. It was far from a perfect weekend, which

started on a sour note after Norris was shunted out on the opening lap of the Sprint Race on Saturday morning.

The McLaren had new parts for this race, and Norris showed great pace all weekend, though he underachieved both in Sprint and the main qualifying. In the Sprint, he was ninth fastest and was taken out by Lance Stroll on the opening lap. The McLaren driver then posted the fifth-fastest time in qualifying for the main race.

On the opening lap, he dropped a position to fall to sixth behind Sergio Perez, while his teammate Oscar Piastri was running up as high as second. But once Perez stopped, Norris unleashed the pace of the McLaren and quickly caught up to Sainz, who was nearly five seconds ahead. Once the top four of Verstappen, Piastri, Leclerc, and Sainz stopped, Norris managed to do respectable times on older tyres and stayed out. It is here that

